Shadows in the Dawn

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My parents used to watch an old show. So old that the only thing more ancient was the TV set on which they watched it. I never watched it—they said I was much too young to see the killings and the murder investigations. Now, after watching it all though, I'm pretty sure it was because neither of them could stand the embarrassment of being in the vicinity of eight-year-old me while sex jokes were made by one of the main characters. The one thing I remember from all those years of padding gently to the edge of the hallway to overlook the living room is a single line: to hide, you either blend in or stand out. There's no half-assing it—that's how you get pinned.

So, a few years back, when they both died and I started to see the disappearances all around me, I had to make a choice: blend in or stand out.

"Hey, can I get another one?" a woman asks, bending further over the bar with shaking hands. I fill her shot glass to the brim with vodka and she breathes a heavy sigh. I always said that food was the best business—it was never a one-time deal. But now, after the split, alcohol really is the way to go. Depression and hopelessness breed all kinds of addictions.

The door creaks, and out slides Feng Min from the basement. I don't know how he can go down there—the lights are always wacky because of the government's electricity cuts and you can't just bust out sprinting when that happens. By the time you get halfway up the stairs the terror fully overtakes you. I'm so glad that he took over that part of my job. I'd be too tempted to risk it otherwise.

Feng Min gestures to the window, where a thin line of gold and white is blossoming at the horizon. It looks like blood from a long gash, the light at the end of the tunnel, salvation. Why did we humans invent heaven and hell? The citizens of the early civilizations were too self-aware. There is no justice in this world, so, to comfort people, that justice must be executed to the most intense degree in the second. So that justice itself may be served while serving justice.

"Hey, it's closing time y'all," he yells out to the crowd. Feng Min and his parents are geniuses at this. If they opened during the day they'd never get any customers. People are too busy working and hoping at daybreak, thinking that stuff about a new dawn and all. But evening and night, that's where it's really at. People have time to relax, and they start to think. Luck of the draw, right? 50% of humanity stays on this hellhole and 50% has to go on rickety ships who knows where. Why'd we get picked to stay here, then? What can we even do, with the

government breaking its treaty pact to attack the Nordic states for their freshwater reserves? What's the point of that new dawn if it shines over a shattered world? My shattered world?

"We need to talk, Lanu. Let's go up top to watch the sun rise" Feng Min turns to me and winks. Of course Feng Min is still peppy after a whole night shift—he's in love. And Emiliano de la Luna arrives today with his diplomat parents after three months of home leave.

We shepherd the last few drunks out the door. One elderly man grips my hand softly, and turns his glassy eyes to me. "Olivia?" He whispers. I shake my head gently and slide his trembling hand to Feng Min's waiting arm. Feng Min is good with people. He'll know just what to say and do.

I step outside, into a shadow world. It's warm already, though my embossed gold pocket watch tells me it's only five in the morning. I know it's summer, so you expect it to be warm, even now, but that's a lie. A lie we all tell ourselves. We all know why it's really that warm. The same reason we had a raffle—the same reason 50% of us had to, or got to, leave.

There's a poster on the side of the Feng's bar. I've seen it every day since I started working there, but I still hate it, still inspect every inch of it as if my life depended on it. Which, given the limited amount of information I have on the feds' new program, is probably true.

The poster's made of some nice paper. That heavy duty cardstock that made up the old wedding invitations my mother used to keep in the attic. No one has that anymore. No one bought it. So no one had the money to make it. That's how you really know it's the government. Not that you needed to deduce it. It says so right at the top, in big red block letters: THE GOVERNMENT OF THE PEOPLE OF THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA. It's like a Cold War propaganda poster, but it's not funny because it's about me. There's the "urges and demands" part. "All citizens." And, as I near the bottom of the page, my body seizes up. "To report any and all individuals displaying extraordinary abilities to any federal officer, so that they may serve their country as all citizens should."

They wouldn't have disappeared people for months before putting up these posters if any semblance of this propaganda had been legit. That's how I confirmed, despite lying to myself for months, that the disappearances were looking for me.

I blink a few times and draw back from the poster, my head cocked and my eyes hooded but calm. I can only see a few shapes ambling away from me, but everything is now an act. An act for and an act of survival. In every episode, the criminals always slipped up in some dumb way, and that's how they were caught. A single look could expose me for the person I am—a criminal, apparently.

"Let's go, Lanu! We're going to miss everything." Feng Min runs up from behind and begins to pull himself up the ladder on the side of the building, next to the poster. He doesn't give it a second glance.

I take a deep breath. Slowing down, being aware of my ability, should be easier after years of climbing this, but I'm still shaking as I grab onto the lower rung. I look up at Feng Min's shoe and count like music in my head as I begin to ascend. 1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and foot and pull and foot and foot and pull and 1 and 2 and 3 and pull yourself up.

The bar's a short building, but I'm breathing heavily as I sit next to Feng Min. He dangles his legs over the edge, but I don't. If I were to fall, I don't trust my will to overpower my survival instinct.

I pull in a deep breath before asking, "What time's he getting here?" It's good to sound a little winded and to draw attention away from me.

"He said he'd be here at around six."

"And, if we're lucky," I add, nudging him, "you'll see his plane from afar and leap up heroically, pining for your kindred spirit!"

"Tell me he's not cute, Lanu. His curly hair is so gorgeous—and—and when he smiles he looks just…just so perfect. And he has the same goal as me, you know—get the world back together. Build back the alliance. Bring hope to all."

"Don't we all," I sigh, turning back to the horizon. "I've only met him twice, and both times for thirty seconds max. It was too formal. You need to get me a chance to interrogate him a bit. I want to know the man whose captured my best friend's heart."

"What about you? Any luck finding a partnership?"

"Nah, I'm not looking right now anyway. Too much stuff going on right now."

"You know what I'm going to say to that."

"Some *carpe diem* quote I know. Fa'amoemoe."

"That means hope, right?"

I laugh. "You're learning. 祈望 Qí wàng?"

"Y'know, those tones really don't like you."

"Tones? Who needs tones when I have my own personal translator right here?" I lean into him.

Feng Min stiffens a bit. "What do you mean?"

I lean back, my chest tightening. Did I do something? Does he know? I instantly leap back into the moment. Any sign of hesitation is dangerous. "Just that you speak like four languages, you fool. What'd you think I meant?"

Feng Min releases, his shoulders curving back down. "Ah, nothing. I heard you wrong. Y'know, my ears aren't what they used to be." He turns to smile at me again, but his eyes are dark with worry.

"You're literally nineteen, Feng Min." I try to laugh but it comes out hoarse.

"Yeah, nineteen is halfway through in this world."

Doors open. People call out quiet greetings while lost in their own thoughts. The sky is a million shades of blue, tiny lines of shades that, from afar, gloss into a solid sheet, a smooth gradient from darkness to white. They remind me of Riemann sums, the addition of all the impossibly minuscule vertical lines under a curve, all to find its the function's area from point a to b. Units that make up a whole. Just like us, each human left on this planet. How big of a Riemann sum would we have to make to connect us all across the universe? Integrals rely on limits, the final action as the distance between the tiny lines goes to zero. Maybe that's it. We're all going to zero, getting closer even if we are further apart. Even if just in our heads.

Feng Min is suddenly dragged back, his bare legs scraping brick as they come over the side of the building. I twist and leap, pulling out a gun I use to scare off customers when they get violent, undo the safety in an instant.

I can feel the heat of the sniper dot on my head as the four men in front of me lift their guns in response to my feeble threat. DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE is on each of their chests. Feng Min has been pushed into a kneeling position, his arms disappearing behind his back. One of the men returns the muzzle back to Feng Min's skull.

The world around us is shimmering slightly, as the air above pavement does in the sun. I'd only heard about these in a whisper, from a man who came through a few months ago. He'd said, once he was half drunk, that the government had finally developed military-capable holographic technology. That'd it'd change the game forever. Tilt the war impossibly far into our favor. It did change the game, but now in they way he'd thought. It's long-term. Get me, then get them.

I can see the beats of escape in my head. Gun down. Run at them. Pull Feng Min. Fire. Disappear.

"Ma'am, please put the gun down. We have authorization to use lethal force if necessary." One of the men tells me. I turn my gaze to look at Feng Min, and he's shaking, his eyes wide with tears. I can hear my mother yelling at the TV in the other room. "A bluff is the first and last card up their sleeves you dumb serial killer!" The game must be played. I cannot reveal my last card.

"What's going on?" I ask, my voice trembling. Would a normal person's voice tremble in this situation? Are normal people afraid of the feds? What would a normal person do in this situation?

"Ma'am, we're from the Department of Defense, Extraordinary Abilities Division. Your friend, Feng Min, has been reported as meeting the qualifications for our program."

I nearly drop my gun, and I slam my teeth together to avoid exhaling all my fear. It's not me. I did not mess up. Then my stomach becomes an empty vat, falling through layers of self-preservation to land on terror. Oh God, Feng Min, what stupid thing did you do? What made you slip up?

"What? That's not possible." I know I can't lie my way out of this. The government is the original trickster. That's why the fox and the crow are friends. You can't hope to trick the trickster. But this is all I've got—no, all I'll use.

The men exchange glances. "Ma'am, we have it on good information that Mr. Feng possesses, to a strong degree, mental abilities that include what is colloquially called mind reading. We'd appreciate your cooperation on this matter."

It's not me. No need for escape, no need for futile attempts at lying or guessing or trapping the feds in their own game. All I need to do is drop the gun. Nod. Stand and wait. Breathe and collapse of joy.

Watch two of the men drag Feng Min down the stairs. The third with his muzzle against that short black hair. And the red dot, sliding down my chest to rest between Feng Min's eyes. The last man, face hidden behind a bulletproof mask, retrieving the holographic disk. Pushing himself off the roof with plain black gloves covered in dust.

And then what? Go down the stairs alone for the first time since I began working here? Stand there? For how long? And just keep watching. And only watching, because silence will follow me even in the bar at midnight, and shadow will hang over my head even at noon. I read Dracula once, years ago, when I still went to school because it still sort of mattered. Jonathan was trapped trapped with a monster, and they both knew the other knew that they knew. He's slowly going crazy. But he'll try to escape like a man rather than die like prey. And he'll escape to return to Mina.

I sprint, pulling up my gun and aiming: one, two, three, four. Kick the man behind Feng Min off the building. Grab his gun. Pull Feng Min up to his knees. The ceiling is wooden here, where Feng Min accidentally made the brick collapse trying to dig a secret tunnel to the roof when he was nine. Feng Min walks to the edge of the building, nodding slightly to me. He knows.

I take a deep breath and raise my arm, slicing it through the air. The flames instantly leap up, a barrier of orange and yellow that radiates heat as if it were the noonday sun itself in all its gold.

We turn and jump. The air is a gentle breeze on my cheek, dark in the shadow of the building. I've never smelt such clean air in my life. It smells like freedom.

A small buzz.

Silence.

It's quiet. And cold. Too cold. A chill is in the air, but it's not soft and edgeless like a mathematical curve of nature. It's jarring and aggressive, a piecewise function, a mere approximation of the delicate changes in the functions that make our world.

The lights are soft and blurred overhead, the room in the peaceful grips of night. I'm in a cushioned bed in the center, the mattress seemingly all around me, a comfortable prison.

My eyes snap open and I push myself off the bed in a single movement. The last guard. How could I have forgotten about him? He was the first one out, so he obviously would've been the first one back into the game. How could I not realize he'd be waiting for us at the bottom?

I twist around. I'm alone in the room. What did I expect? The government isn't foolish enough to put two best friends with powers in the same room.

How could I have been so stupid? We were so close, so close, so close. And I ruined it. I ruined it for myself. I ruined it for both of us. All of our chances, dashed. I learned in biology that very few theories actually become laws, because biology is so variable that it is impossible to apply a single phrase to everything, even in a specialized subcategory. In detective shows, there's only one law. The criminals always slip up in the end.

I hear a soft knock at the other end of the room, and my head jumps up. A door. My eyes narrow. Escape. If I can only figure out the door. But they must be expecting that. And breaking into a place is hard enough. If they know you're coming and who you're coming for, it'll be next to impossible.

Patience is a virtue few possess, and even fewer apply.

"Come in," I call out, smiling at the cruel irony of a prisoner being asked to allow her jailer into her cell, even though she has no other choice.

"Good evening, Ms. Lanuola. How are you feeling?" An elderly woman in a white lab coat walks in, carrying purple glass sheet.

"Fine." I shrug.

"Do you know where you are?" She asks, her eyes tilting kindly.

"I'm pretty sure I can hazard a guess." I clench my teeth.

"You're at the Department of Defense central quarters, Extraordinary Abilities Division, Health sector."

"And lo, I was right."

"Since you're still recovering—" she begins, at which I tilt my head to the side and look at her from under my eyelids, crossing my arms. Smiling a little at me, she continues, "Your training won't start until next Monday. Today is Wednesday,

for reference. 2300 hours, to be exact. I'll leave you to rest. You've had a long day." She nods once more and begins to walk towards the door.

"Training for what?" comes out from the base of my throat, teasing a guttural cry of fury.

She turns around slightly, her eyes almost kind. "Why, Ms. Lanuola, you're going to be a superhero." She shuts the door without a sound behind her.

"Beauty is in the eye of the beholder," I mutter, lying down on the floor and spreading out my arms. "And so is if this program creates super*heroes*."

The room is silent in reply.